VTU MBA – MODULE 5 STUDY NOTES

TEAMS • POWER & POLITICS • CONFLICT & NEGOTIATION

Detailed Study Notes

IMPORTANT SYLLABUS VERIFICATION

The syllabus supplied in your message is NOT the current Module 5 of VTU MBA106 Managerial Communication. It matches Module 5 of VTU MBA101 Management & Organisational Behaviour (8 hours) in the current 2024–25 MBA syllabus. I have therefore prepared these notes for the exact topics you supplied, but I have not falsely labelled them as MBA106 Managerial Communication content.

Current MBA106 Managerial Communication Module 5 covers Case Method of Learning, Employment Communication and Technology-enabled Communication; this is a different syllabus.

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1. Truth-Mode Syllabus Alignment

Your supplied topic	Current VTU MBA101 status
Teams: meaning, advantages, model of team effectiveness, stages of team development	Module 5
Power & Politics: meaning, sources, contingencies, consequences, politics	Module 5
Conflict and Negotiation in the workplace: constructive & relationship conflict; conflict process; structural sources; negotiation; third-party resolution	Module 5

The current official VTU MBA101 syllabus gives these topics 8 hours. 毅cite孳turn2search5傢

Truth-mode interpretation of one phrase: the syllabus wording says “Structural sources of Conflict Management.” In these notes, this is handled as structural sources of conflict and the corresponding structural approaches to conflict management, because the surrounding topics and standard OB framing clearly concern why organizational structures generate conflict and how those conditions can be changed. This is an interpretation, not a claim that VTU supplied a longer definition.

Source discipline

- Current syllabus statements are source-grounded.
- Team effectiveness and power contingencies are explained using the conceptual framework represented in the supplied study material and cross-checked against the relevant OB framework.
- Team-development guidance is also consistent with the supplied Guffey material.
- Examples, cases, diagrams and sample workplace situations in this document are instructional constructions unless explicitly identified as historical.
- Historical VTU questions are evidence of past assessment patterns, not predictions.

2. One Mental Model for the Entire Module

Concept	Core question
Teams	How do people work together to accomplish something they cannot efficiently accomplish alone?
Team effectiveness	What makes a team actually produce useful results?
Power	Who can influence whom, and why?
Politics	How is influence pursued when interests, resources or preferences differ?
Conflict	Where do goals, processes, resources or relationships collide?
Negotiation	Can the parties reach an acceptable agreement themselves?
Third-party resolution	What happens when they cannot resolve the dispute directly?

High-scoring answers connect concepts rather than treating them as isolated definitions.

3. Teams

3.1 Meaning of a Team

A team is a group whose members are interdependent, coordinate their work, share a common purpose and understand themselves as a team. The critical idea is interdependence: members need one another's contributions to achieve the common purpose.

Group	Team
Members may work largely independently.	Members depend on one another.
Individual goals may dominate.	Shared purpose is central.
Coordination may be limited.	Coordination and communication are essential.
Team identity may be weak.	Members perceive a collective identity.

3.2 When Teams Add Value

- Complex tasks require different expertise.
- Work is genuinely interdependent.
- Multiple perspectives improve decision quality.
- Implementation requires cross-functional ownership.
- Learning and knowledge sharing are important.

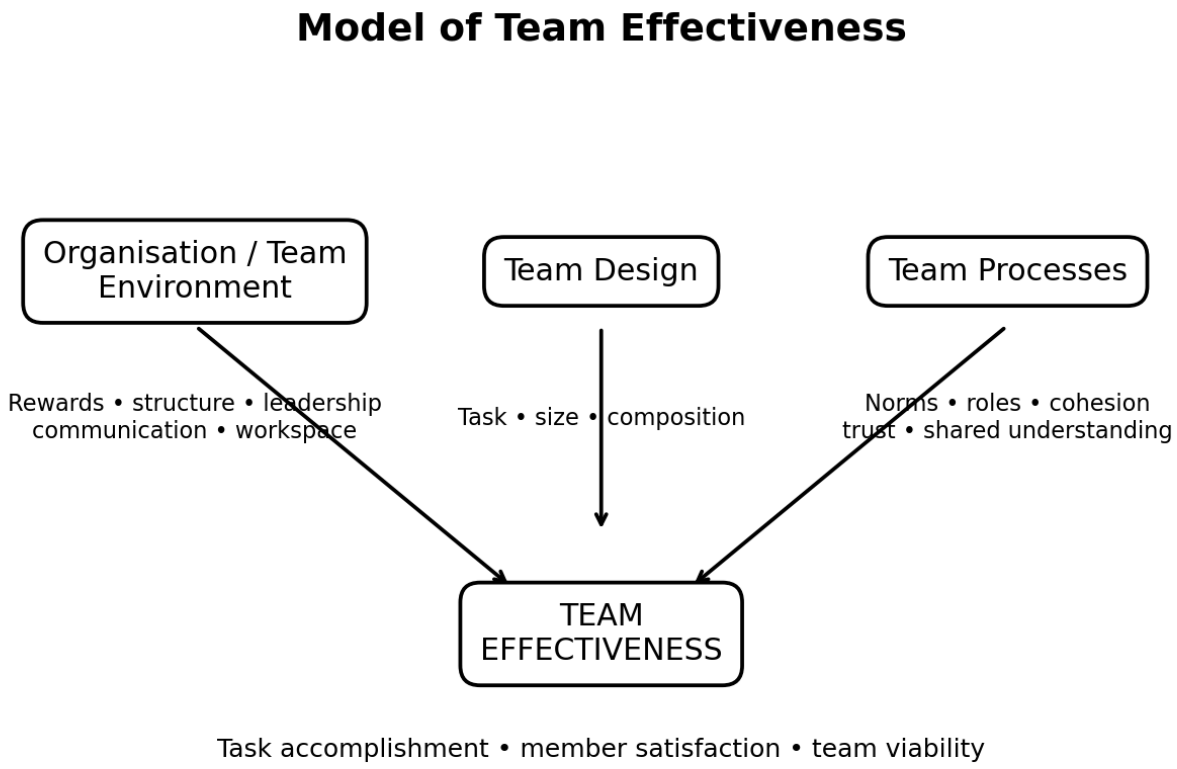
When a Team May NOT Be the Best Choice

- A simple task can be completed efficiently by one person.
- Coordination costs exceed the benefits of collaboration.
- A very rapid decision is needed and consultation adds little value.
- There is no meaningful interdependence.

3.3 Advantages and Limitations

Advantage	Why it can help	Possible limitation
Better decisions	Multiple perspectives can expose assumptions.	Groupthink can suppress dissent.
Higher productivity	Work can be divided according to expertise.	Coordination consumes time.
Faster response	Members can work in parallel.	Dependencies can create delays.
Greater buy-in	Participation can increase commitment.	Dominant members can influence outcomes excessively.
Improved morale	Teams can provide support and belonging.	Relationship conflict can damage morale.
Risk reduction	Different members notice different risks.	Too many opinions can slow action.

3.4 Model of Team Effectiveness



The model links three broad drivers to effectiveness: the organization/team environment, team design and team processes. Effectiveness is not simply "members getting along"; it concerns accomplishing the task while meeting member needs and maintaining the team's viability.

Component	Key elements	Diagnostic question
Environment	Rewards, structure, communication systems, leadership, physical/technical setting	Does the organization support teamwork?
Team design	Task characteristics, size, composition	Is this the right team for this task?
Team processes	Development, norms, roles, cohesion, trust, shared understanding	How does the team actually work together?
Effectiveness	Task accomplishment, member satisfaction, viability	Did the team achieve its purpose sustainably?

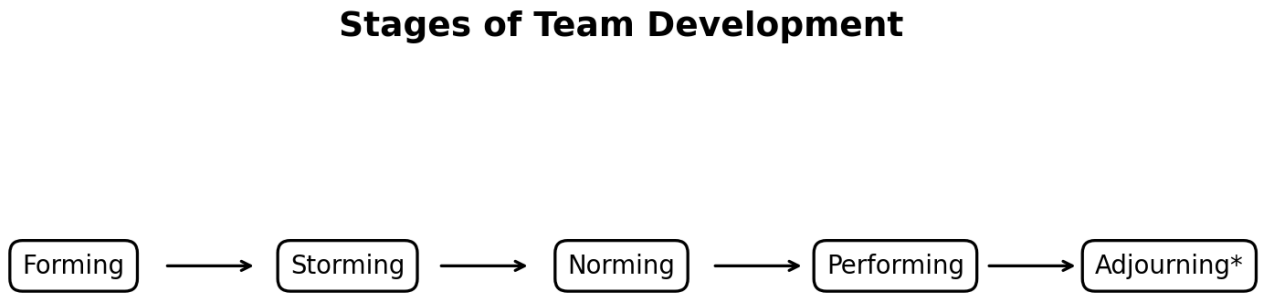
Worked Application

A college creates a 7-member team to launch a student-services app. IT provides technical expertise; Finance controls the budget; Student Affairs understands users; Marketing owns launch communication. After two months, the team is stalled.

Model element	Diagnosis	Possible intervention

Environment	Reward system recognizes department targets, not project success.	Add shared project goals and recognition.
Design	Finance is involved but has no agreed decision role.	Clarify authority and decision rights.
Processes	Members withhold information and meetings become defensive.	Establish norms, shared information, issue escalation and decision rules.
Effectiveness	Launch is delayed and trust is falling.	Set measurable milestones and review team functioning.

4. Stages of Team Development



*Adjourning is a later extension commonly used for temporary teams.

Stage	Typical behaviour	Managerial response
Forming	Members meet, learn purpose, roles and expectations; initial uncertainty is common.	Clarify purpose, roles, procedures and success criteria.
Storming	Disagreement over roles, methods, priorities or influence.	Surface issues; keep disagreement task-focused; coach and clarify decision rules.
Norming	Shared norms, roles and trust become clearer; coordination improves.	Reinforce productive norms; increase shared responsibility.
Performing	Team operates with stronger coordination and task focus.	Delegate, remove barriers, monitor outcomes and sustain learning.
Adjourning*	Temporary team completes its mandate and closes.	Capture learning, recognize contributions and close responsibilities.

*Adjourning is a later extension commonly associated with temporary teams; the four core phases are forming, storming, norming and performing.

Case — New Product Team

Situation: A six-member product team is polite during week 1. By week 3, Marketing demands an aggressive launch, Operations says the date is unrealistic, and two members dispute ownership of customer research.

Tasks:

1. Identify the likely development stage.
2. Give two managerial actions.
3. What evidence would suggest the team is moving toward norming?

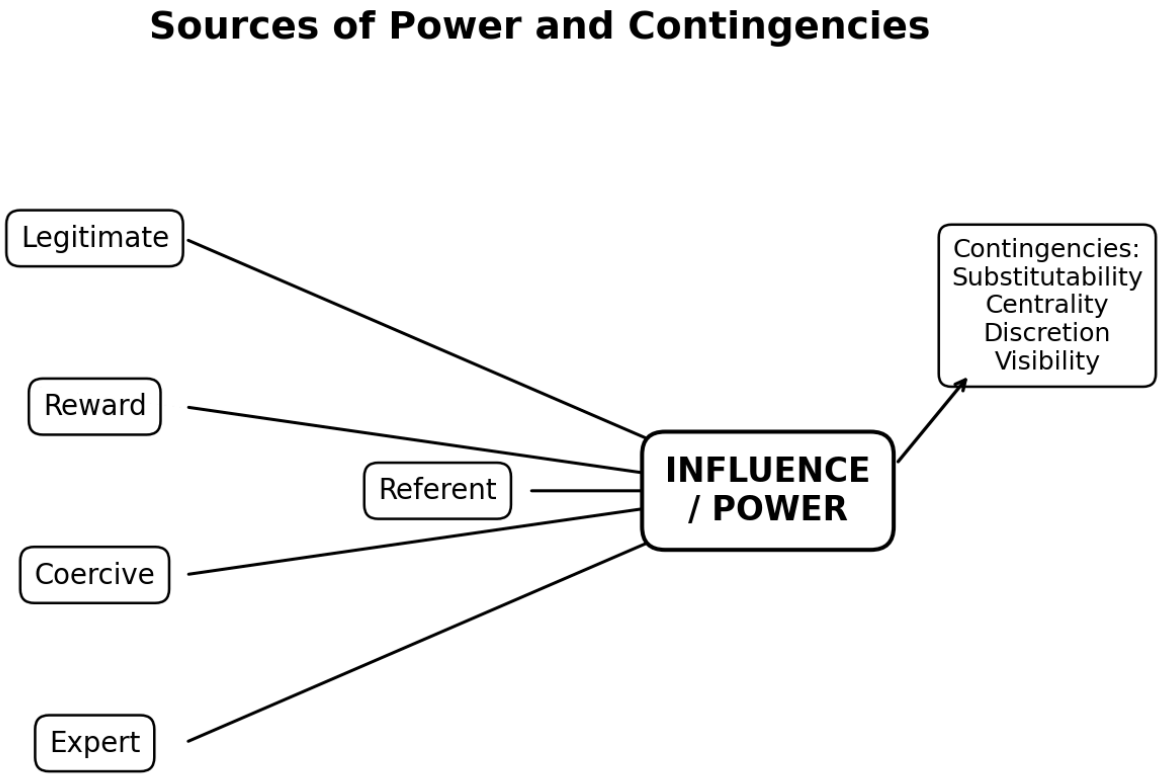
Suggested analysis:

- The likely stage is storming because roles, priorities and methods are being contested.
- Clarify roles, decision rights and evidence requirements; keep the disagreement about the work rather than personalities.
- Agreed procedures, clearer roles, more open information sharing and reduced personal friction are signs of norming.

5. Power & Politics

5.1 Meaning of Power

Power is the capacity to influence others or affect decisions, resources or behaviour. Authority is formal legitimacy associated with a role; power can also arise from rewards, sanctions, expertise or personal identification/respect.



5.2 Sources of Power

Source	Meaning	Workplace example
Legitimate power	Influence based on a recognized right attached to a role.	A department head assigns work within formal authority.
Reward power	Influence from controlling valued rewards.	A manager controls recognition, desirable assignments or approved benefits within policy.
Coercive power	Influence through negative consequences or sanctions.	A manager can initiate disciplinary action under established policy.
Expert power	Influence because others value knowledge or skill.	A cybersecurity specialist shapes a security decision.
Referent power	Influence based on respect, admiration or identification.	A trusted leader influences peers without relying on formal authority.

5.3 Contingencies of Power

Contingency	Question	Effect on influence
Substitutability	Are alternatives to what I control readily available?	Few substitutes generally increase dependence and practical power.
Centrality	How important is my resource/role to the workflow?	More central resources can create greater influence.
Discretion	How much freedom do I have to decide or allocate?	Greater discretion can increase practical influence.
Visibility	Do relevant people know that I control something important?	Power that is invisible may be less usable.

5.4 Consequences of Power

- Power can enable coordination, rapid decisions and resource allocation.
- Expert or referent power can improve influence without relying on formal authority.
- Excessive or unchecked power can suppress dissent and create dependency.
- Coercive use can create fear, avoidance and reduced voice.
- Power can be used constructively or destructively; power itself is not automatically unethical.

5.5 Politics in Organizations

Organizational politics refers to influence behaviour used to advance interests, priorities or outcomes when resources, goals or preferences are not fully aligned. Politics is not automatically unethical; the risk arises when influence becomes deceptive, manipulative, unfair or inconsistent with organizational goals and rules.

Constructive influence	Dysfunctional politics
Uses evidence and legitimate influence.	Withholds information to manipulate a decision.
Builds coalitions around organizational goals.	Builds coalitions only to protect personal interests.
Makes interests visible.	Uses hidden agendas.
Challenges decisions respectfully.	Retaliates against dissent.
Uses influence within rules.	Bypasses controls for personal advantage.

Managing Dysfunctional Politics

4. Clarify decision rights and accountability.
5. Make criteria for decisions explicit.
6. Increase transparency of important information.
7. Reduce unnecessary resource dependence where practical.
8. Document major decisions and conflicts of interest.
9. Protect legitimate dissent and escalation channels.
10. Model ethical influence from leadership.

6. Conflict in the Workplace

6.1 Meaning

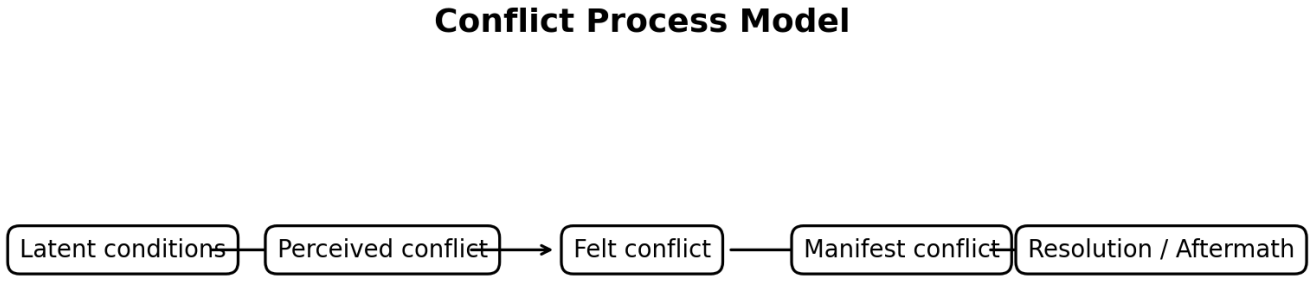
Workplace conflict occurs when people or groups perceive incompatible interests, goals, expectations, resources, processes or relationships. Conflict is not automatically destructive; its effect depends on what the conflict is about, how intense it becomes and how it is managed.

6.2 Constructive / Task Conflict vs Relationship Conflict

Constructive / task-focused conflict	Relationship conflict
Concerned with ideas, methods, priorities or evidence.	Concerned with personal incompatibility, hostility or interpersonal friction.
Can expose assumptions and improve decisions when controlled.	Usually consumes attention and damages trust.
Can encourage alternatives and deeper analysis.	Can create avoidance, defensiveness and reduced cooperation.
Manager should keep disagreement focused on the issue.	Manager should reduce personal attacks and repair working relationships.

Important: not every disagreement is relationship conflict. A team can disagree strongly about a launch date while remaining respectful.

6.3 Conflict Process Model



Stage	Meaning	Example
Latent conditions	Structural/interpersonal conditions capable of producing conflict exist.	Two departments depend on the same limited budget.
Perceived conflict	Someone recognizes incompatibility.	Marketing realizes Finance will not approve the requested spend.
Felt conflict	Conflict becomes emotionally experienced.	Frustration and defensiveness increase.
Manifest conflict	Conflict becomes observable in behaviour.	Arguments, refusal to cooperate or escalation occur.

Resolution / aftermath	Conflict is managed/resolved or leaves consequences.	Agreement is reached—or resentment remains and affects future work.

6.4 Why the Process Model Matters

Early intervention is often easier. If a manager notices structural incompatibility at the latent stage, redesigning goals or resources may prevent escalation. Once conflict becomes personal and manifest, the manager may need both substantive problem-solving and relationship repair.

7. Structural Sources of Conflict & Management

Common Structural Sources of Workplace Conflict



Structural source	How conflict can arise	Possible management response
Incompatible goals	One unit wants speed; another prioritizes cost/control.	Create shared goals and explicit trade-offs.
Differentiation	Departments develop different priorities, language and measures.	Cross-functional forums and shared metrics.
Interdependence	One unit cannot complete work without another.	Clarify handoffs, SLAs, dependencies and escalation paths.
Scarce resources	Departments compete for budget, people or equipment.	Use transparent allocation criteria and priority rules.
Ambiguous rules	People disagree about who owns a decision.	Clarify roles, authority and decision rights.
Communication problems	Incomplete, delayed or distorted information creates assumptions.	Create reliable information channels and confirmation mechanisms.

Structural Intervention Principle

Do not treat every organizational conflict as a personality problem. If the structure repeatedly creates the same conflict, changing the people without changing the structure may only reproduce the problem.

Case — Finance vs Marketing

Situation: Marketing promises a customer campaign within ten days. Finance requires documented approvals and says the requested budget is unavailable. Marketing accuses Finance of blocking growth; Finance accuses Marketing of ignoring controls.

Tasks:

11. Identify at least three structural sources of conflict.
12. Which part is task conflict and which part is relationship conflict?
13. Recommend structural interventions.

Suggested analysis:

- Interdependence exists because both functions are needed for the campaign.

- Goals differ: growth speed versus financial control.
- Rules/authority may be ambiguous if the campaign approval threshold is unclear.
- The accusations are relationship conflict and should not replace the substantive discussion.
- Create approval thresholds, shared campaign milestones, a common budget rule and an escalation path.

8. Resolving Conflict Through Negotiation

Negotiation is a process in which parties with different or partly overlapping interests communicate to reach an agreement. In workplace conflict, effective negotiation focuses on the underlying interests and practical options rather than simply trying to 'win'.



8.1 Preparation

14. Define the issue and desired outcome.
15. Separate positions from underlying interests.
16. Identify your minimum acceptable outcome and alternatives if no agreement is reached.
17. Understand the other party's likely interests and constraints.
18. Collect facts and distinguish facts from assumptions.
19. Identify options that could satisfy both sides.

8.2 Position vs Interest

Position	Underlying interest
“We need the launch on Monday.”	Revenue opportunity, customer commitment, competitive timing.
“We cannot approve Monday.”	Compliance, risk control, capacity and quality assurance.
Negotiation question	Can the parties redesign the plan to address both sets of interests?

8.3 BATNA and ZOPA — Use Carefully

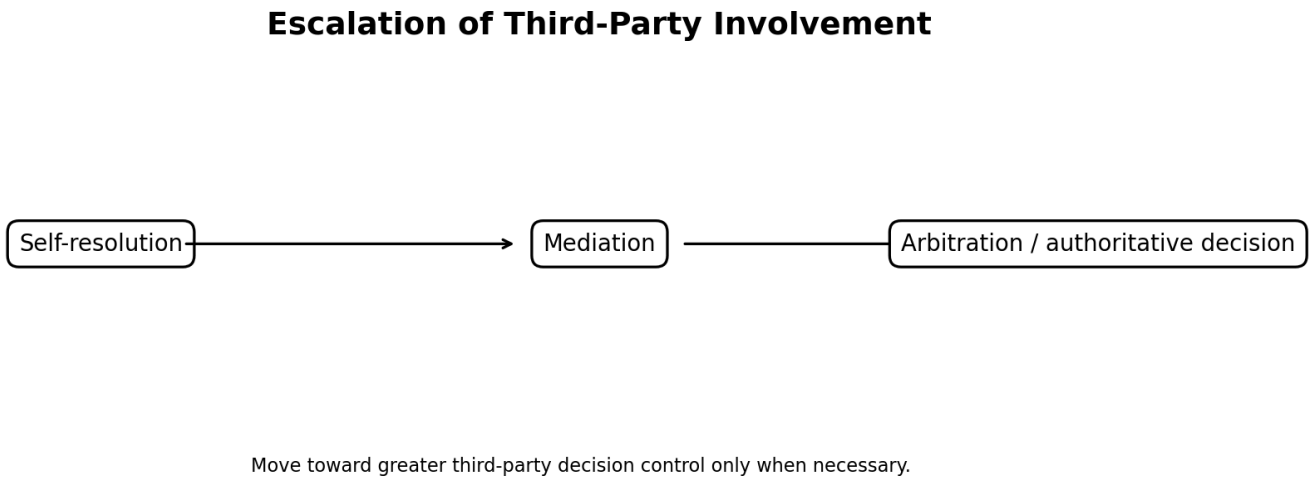
BATNA (Best Alternative to a Negotiated Agreement) is the best practical alternative available if no agreement is reached. ZOPA (Zone of Possible Agreement) is the range in which the parties' acceptable outcomes overlap. These concepts are widely used in negotiation analysis, but they are not explicitly named in the supplied VTU MBA101 Module 5 wording; they are included here as useful applied negotiation tools, not as mandatory syllabus terms.

Concept	Simple example
BATNA	If supplier negotiations fail, the company can use an alternate supplier at a known cost and delay.
ZOPA	Buyer can pay ₹95–105 per unit; seller can accept ₹100–110. The overlap is ₹100–105.

8.4 Negotiation Errors

- Treating a position as if it were the only possible solution.
- Negotiating before understanding the facts.
- Making threats that cannot be carried out.
- Confusing firmness with aggression.
- Failing to record the final agreement.
- Solving the immediate issue while leaving the structural cause untouched.

9. Third-Party Conflict Resolution



Third-party intervention is useful when direct negotiation fails, emotions are high, a power imbalance prevents productive discussion, or the parties need an independent process.

Method	Third party's role	Who controls the outcome?	Best fit

Mediation	Facilitates communication and helps parties develop options.	The parties retain decision control.	Relationship or process dispute where continued working relationship matters.
Arbitration	Hears the dispute and makes a decision/award under the agreed process.	The arbitrator controls the decision within the process.	Parties need a more formal decision process.
Authoritative intervention	An authorized superior/body makes or directs a decision within its authority.	The authority makes the decision.	Urgent or governance-related matters where organizational authority must act.

Mediation vs Arbitration

Mediation	**Arbitration**
Facilitator helps parties reach their own agreement.	Third party decides the dispute under the agreed process.
Decision control remains with parties.	Decision control shifts to arbitrator.
Often useful when preserving the relationship is important.	Useful when a formal determination is required.
Flexible and collaborative.	More adjudicative/formal.

Practical escalation rule

20. Try direct, structured negotiation where feasible.
21. Use mediation when communication needs facilitation and parties can still own the solution.
22. Use arbitration or another authoritative process when a decision must be imposed through an agreed or legitimate process.
23. After resolution, fix the underlying structural cause where possible.

10. Integrated Case Studies

Case 1 — The Student-Service Team

Situation: IT, Finance, Student Affairs and Marketing are building a student-service platform. IT controls technical knowledge, Finance controls budget, Student Affairs controls user access, and Marketing wants a rapid launch. Members now withhold information and the project is delayed.

Tasks:

24. Apply the Model of Team Effectiveness.
25. Identify two sources of power and their contingencies.
26. Diagnose the conflict using the Conflict Process Model.
27. Recommend a negotiation approach.
28. Would mediation or arbitration be the better first third-party intervention? Explain.

Suggested analysis:

- Environment: incentives and decision rules may reward departmental rather than shared outcomes.
- Design: cross-functional expertise is appropriate, but authority and decision rights may be unclear.
- Processes: withholding information indicates weak trust/norms.
- Power sources include expert power (IT) and legitimate/resource power (Finance). Centrality and discretion may increase their practical influence.
- The conflict may have moved from latent structural conditions to perceived/felt conflict and manifest information withholding.
- Negotiation should focus on shared launch interests, decision rights, milestones and trade-offs.
- Mediation is generally more suitable as a first third-party step when parties must continue working together and can still own the solution.

Case 2 — High Performer, High Coercion

Situation: A plant manager achieves excellent short-term production results by using formal authority and threats of disciplinary action. Supervisors comply but stop raising problems. When the manager is transferred, performance falls sharply.

Tasks:

29. Identify the power sources being used.
30. What are the consequences of this power pattern?
31. Why might performance fall after the manager leaves?
32. What should the organization change?

Suggested analysis:

- Legitimate and coercive power dominate.
- Silencing voice creates information risk and dependency on the manager.
- Employees may comply rather than internalize standards or build shared capability.

- Build shared processes, develop supervisors, use expert/reward/referent influence, encourage upward communication and reduce dependence on one individual.

Case 3 — Budget Conflict

Situation: Two departments need the same five additional employees. Each claims its project is strategically critical. The organization has only five positions available.

Tasks:

33. Identify the structural source of conflict.
34. What information should be collected before negotiation?
35. Develop two possible integrative options.
36. When might an authoritative decision be necessary?

Suggested analysis:

- Scarce resources and potentially incompatible goals are central.
- Collect workload, revenue/risk impact, deadlines, dependencies and alternative staffing options.
- Options might include phased staffing, temporary shared resources, automation, or reprioritization.
- An authorized executive decision may be needed when the parties cannot agree and a time-critical allocation must be made.

11. Historical VTU Examination Questions

Historical questions below are clearly identified. The official 20MBA11 model paper is for the older 2020 scheme; it is useful for seeing how VTU framed teams, power and organizational politics, but it is not a current MBA101 2024–25 paper.

11.1 Questions from the Historical VTU Model Paper

Historical question	What it demonstrates
"What is group dynamics?" (3 marks)	Short-definition / concept question.
"Explain the impact of group on individual's behavior" (7 marks)	Concept + explanation question.
"Explain in detail the process of teamwork" (10 marks)	Long-form team question.
"Explain types of teams and the reasons for team failure" (10 marks)	Application-oriented team question.
"Which are different sources of power for individuals?" (3 marks)	Direct power-source recall question.
"Discuss how organizational politics can be managed" (10 marks)	Applied politics-management question.
Compulsory case questions requiring organizational diagnosis (20 marks total in the model paper)	VTU has used case-based application in Management & OB.

Source: official VTU 20MBA11 SEE model paper. 毅cite孳turn3view0傢

14. One-Page Revision Sheet

Topic	Memory hook
Team	Interdependence + common purpose + coordination.
Advantages	Better decisions, productivity, response, buy-in, morale, risk identification.
Team effectiveness	Environment → Design → Processes → Effectiveness.
Stages	Form → Storm → Norm → Perform → Adjourning*.
Power sources	Legitimate + Reward + Coercive + Expert + Referent.
Power contingencies	Substitutability + Centrality + Discretion + Visibility.
Politics	Influence for interests; constructive when legitimate, dysfunctional when manipulative.
Conflict	Task/constructive ≠ relationship conflict.
Conflict process	Latent → Perceived → Felt → Manifest → Resolution/Aftermath.
Structural sources	Goals + differentiation + interdependence + scarce resources + ambiguous rules + communication.
Negotiation	Prepare → Interests → Options → Trade-offs → Agreement → Implementation.
Mediation	Third party facilitates; parties retain solution ownership.
Arbitration	Third party decides under the agreed process.

Final mental model: TEAMS = How do we work together? POWER = Who can influence what? POLITICS = How is influence pursued? CONFLICT = Why are goals/processes/relationships colliding? NEGOTIATION = Can the parties create an agreement? THIRD-PARTY RESOLUTION = What happens when they cannot resolve it themselves?

15. Sources & Truth-Mode Notes

- VTU, 1st Semester MBA syllabus for AY 2024–25 onwards, MBA101 Management & Organisational Behaviour — current source for the supplied topics and 8-hour Module 5 allocation. 毅cite孳turn2search5傢
- VTU, 2024–25 MBA106 Managerial Communication syllabus — used to verify that the supplied topics are not current MBA106 Module 5. 毅cite孳turn1search12傢
- Official VTU 20MBA11 SEE Model Question Paper — historical evidence for teamwork, team failure, sources of power and organizational politics questions. 毅cite孳turn3view0傢
- Supplied Guffey, Business Communication: Process & Product — supplementary support for teamwork and workplace conflict practices.
- Supplied/previously retrieved Management & Organisational Behaviour study material — used to preserve the terminology and exam-oriented framing of the supplied topic set.

Truth-mode boundary: this document does not claim that newly constructed practice questions appeared in VTU exams. It distinguishes current syllabus facts, historical question evidence, conceptual frameworks and instructional examples.

END OF MODULE 5 STUDY NOTES